

Political philosophy



Where ethics and moral philosophy seek to define virtue and what constitutes the ‘good life’, the closely related branch of political philosophy examines the nature of concepts such as justice, and what sort of society can best allow its citizens to lead ‘good’ lives. The problems of how society should be organized and governed were of paramount importance not only to classical Greece, but also in the development of nation-states in China at much the same time, and elsewhere as new civilizations emerged.

As a branch of philosophy, political philosophy deals with ideas of justice, liberty and rights, and the relationship between a state and its citizens. It also examines various forms of government, such as monarchy, aristocracy, oligarchy, tyranny and democracy, how each affects the rights and freedoms of the individual, and how they exert their authority through rule of law.